

Online Copyright Infringement in the EU (2017–2023): Key Findings

Illegal IPTV has matured into a professionalized industry, deliberately mirroring legitimate platforms with polished interfaces, monthly subscription plans, VoD libraries, and business-to-business (b2b) reseller packages. The illicit European IPTV market generated approximately EUR 1.06 billion in 2021, and the share of EU internet users visiting pirate IPTV registration sites grew from 1.95% per month in 2022 to 2.14% in 2023. The seasonal pattern of that traffic, peaking during football seasons and collapsing in summer, confirms that live sports is the primary engine driving IPTV demand.

The econometric analysis across 27 Member States shows that piracy is shaped by local economic conditions. Income inequality (Gini coefficient) is the most consistent predictor: greater inequality drives piracy up across all content types, as large segments of the population cannot afford legal alternatives. GDP per capita operates differently depending on content: wealthier countries show lower film piracy, but paradoxically higher live sports piracy, where premium pricing and subscription fatigue push even affluent users toward illegal options. Youth unemployment increases film and sports piracy through reduced disposable income, yet counterintuitively reduces music and TV piracy, possibly because unemployed youth live with parents who maintain paid subscriptions.

From 2017 to 2023, film piracy declined steadily and TV piracy stabilized, while software and live sports/IPTV continued growing. Software piracy is driven almost entirely by mobile apps and games, tracking the shift to mobile-first consumption. Live sports piracy reflects the increasing concentration of high-demand content behind expensive paywalls, reinforcing IPTV as the preferred vehicle for unauthorized access.

Effective countermeasures in 2026 must operate on two fronts. On the supply side, AI-driven real-time stream fingerprinting with dynamic injunctions can block unauthorized streams within minutes, while forensic watermarking traces pirated feeds back to their source account, targeting the reseller networks at the heart of the IPTV chain. On the demand side, a third technical measure involves automated DNS and IP blocking systems paired with real-time legal injunctions, enabling rights holders to take down unauthorized streams within minutes of detection as demonstrated by enforcement frameworks already operating in Italy and the Netherlands.